burial place of the Barakzais. Moreover, it was controlled by two powerful and respected hereditary Naqsbandi sheikhs from Kohistan, Mir Masjidi and his brother Mir Haji, who was also the hereditary Imam of the Pul-i-Khishti Friday Mosque and the leader of the Kabul ‘ulema.[79] They were enormously influential figures and the Anglo-Sadozai regime should have done all it could to keep them within the Shah’s inner circle. Instead it seemed to be doing all it could to alienate them.

To aggravate matters further, the British also interfered in the mullahs’ administration of justice. The ‘ulema understandably didn’t like being lectured on the Sharia by the conceited Macnaghten who was now writing, ‘I have gained a complete victory over the Moollas who have since freely admitted that my knowledge of the Mahomedan Law is superior to their own.’[80] Most of all they disliked the way the ‘licentious infidels’ were corrupting their city, and strongly objected to the daily spectacle of carousing British and Indian squaddies openly drinking and whoring in their streets.

These conservative objections to the British presence were shared by the nobility. In the summer of 1840, the British intercepted a letter from a senior Barakzai leader, Sultan Mohammad Khan, the former Governor of Peshawar, who wrote to his half-brother Dost Mohammad complaining, ‘I cannot tell you what oppression is committed by the Firangis. Some of the people have publicly turned Christians and others have turned prostitute. Grain has got very dear. May God turn this accursed set out of the country as their appearance has discarded both religion and modesty.’[81]

All this came to a head in July 1840 when, at the instigation of Mir Haji, the ‘ulema began to omit proclaiming the name of Shah Shuja at Friday prayers, on the grounds that the real rulers were the Kafirs. According to Burnes, the Shah immediately summoned him to the Bala Hisar and told him:

> that in the city of Kabul he was assailed night & day by mullahs and others who represented the present state of things as anything but a Mahommedan Kingdom and asked him that if the Shah was of the same opinion a rebellion or insurrection was easily raised against the British. Of course, said His Majesty, I have endeavoured to correct the erroneous opinions of these men by assuring them that the English and I are as two hearts in one body. Yet I cannot hope to get them to think so when in the capital the troops are not my own and their movements take place without my knowledge . . . H.M. observed that it was a plain fiction to call the officers and men whom the Gov. Genl. had placed at his disposal as his own, that none of the officers ever came near him, or even acted as his, and it was no wonder therefore that his subjects increasingly